

CDN Incident Alert: 106. TLP: CLEAR		Date
Title	MD Russia alleges political persecution and human rights violations following sentencing of Evghenia Guțul	27/10/2025

Summary

- Russian officials and state media used the sentencing of Evghenia Guțul, the pro-Kremlin governor of the Autonomous Territorial Unit Gagauzia, to discredit the Moldovan government and the judiciary system, as well as frame the subsequent protests in support of Guțul as evidence of a fissure in Moldovan society.
- Russian officials and Russian state-backed media claimed that the sentencing aimed to eliminate a popular contender during the upcoming parliamentary elections, while arguing that the dispersion of those demonstrating in support of Guțul was a violation of their civic rights of assembly.
- Between August 5 and 31, Russian officials and Russian state-backed media produced at least 143 messages in support of Guțul. The most popular of the messages that featured malign narratives cumulatively received 18,250 likes, 709 shares, and 1.2 million views.
- The campaign relied on distortion and division, and attracted traditional media to degrade adversaries, namely the current Moldovan government, and develop competing narratives about Guțul's verdict being unjust.
- Recommendations include countering disinformation by exposing inaccurate narratives and coordinating counter-messaging across Moldovan governmental branches.

Incident

On August 5, a Moldovan court [jailed](#) Evghenia Guțul. She [received](#) a sentence of seven years for illegal financing of the now-banned party of Ilan Șor, an exiled pro-Russian Moldovan businessman. Prosecutors [said](#) that Guțul channelled undeclared funds into Moldova between 2019 and 2022. Gagauzia's parliament protested the sentence and placed responsibility for any escalation of Guțul's persecution on Moldovan authorities. The Kremlin [labelled](#) the verdict as politically motivated and [accused](#) Moldova's government of suppressing pro-Russian views in Moldova. Following the arrest, protesters [gathered](#) outside the prison in Chișinău, where Guțul is being held. Moldovan law enforcement officers [filed](#) dozens of reports regarding the acceptance of remuneration for participating in these protests. After several activists were arrested and fined, Șor, the current leader of the pro-Russian Victory bloc, [appealed](#) in a [video message](#) for continued protests and promised \$100 daily to those who join the protest. Moldovan police [warned](#) that these protests were illegal and later [dismantled](#) protesters' tents and [detained](#) 69 people.

Overall, there were at least 4,446 publications about Guțul's prosecution in Russian language on August 5 - 31 identified via the Osavul narrative analysis tool. There were 756 web publications, 2,922 Telegram posts, 312 Facebook posts, 208 TikTok videos, 111 VKontakte (VK) posts, 87 X posts, and 50 YouTube videos. Unsurprisingly, VK, Telegram, X, and web pages contained the highest ratios of accounts or domains previously involved in information manipulation and/or being Russia state-affiliated as determined by Osavul. Over a half (53 percent) of web pages mentioning the topic were previously involved in information manipulation activities and 35 percent of the pages were Russia state affiliated. On VK, 70 percent of posts were by manipulative accounts, mostly Russia state-affiliated. On Telegram, 37 percent of accounts were manipulative and 12 percent Russia state-affiliated. On X, 21 percent of accounts were previously involved in information manipulation. There was also at least one RT video supporting Guțul, which appeared on video platform Rumble [popular](#) among American conservative and far-right users. This video gathered 48 likes and just over 4,000 views. Additionally, Telegram channels @Gagauznews (12,987 subscribers) and @Gagauzia24 (14,829 subscribers) also reposted RT messages and statements by Kremlin's and Russia's Ministry of Foreign Affairs spokespersons, gathering at least 11,842 views.

Systemic Violation Assessment

Russia's narratives represent a risk because they could potentially harm an electoral process by undermining Moldovan citizens' trust in the current Moldovan government. They could also exacerbate perception of existing tensions between Gagauzian minority and pro-Russian Moldovans on the one side and official Chișinău on the other side.

This incident constitutes manipulation of information because Russian officials and state-backed media omit unfavourable facts about Guțul's sentence and misrepresent it as political persecution. Similarly, Russian state-backed

media omit the fact that Șor's protests were not coordinated and approved with local Moldovan authorities, resulting in detention of protesters. Some Russian state-backed media also overestimated the number of detained protesters, more than doubling the figure from 69 to 150.

Russian state media outlets are officially banned in Moldova, yet their narratives can spread through other sources of information, such as Telegram channels, that repost such content. That can be considered to be an illegal circumvention of the Moldovan law.

Narrative

Meta narrative: Sandu's government persecutes political opponents and violates citizens' rights.

Sub-narratives: Guțul's sentence is politically motivated disgrace, disregard for the rule of law, fabricated case with numerous violations and without evidence, unprecedented act of inhumanity supported by Europe; Sandu's government intensifies open struggle against influential opposition politicians ahead of key elections, hates "true patriots", and repeats "the Ukrainian scenario"; Guțul's sentence allows to increase pressure on the local population to prevent mass protests: authorities had repeatedly obstructed demonstrations supporting Guțul and arrested about 150 participants of the "Victory" bloc; Guțul's supporters seek support from US President Donald Trump and the OSCE.

Impact

Reach: 459 manipulative accounts produced 1.59 thousand publications that reached 20.5 million views and garnered 412 thousand reactions. 164 of these accounts were Russia state-affiliated.

Outcome: Demonstrations and protests in Chișinău; Gagauzian, Transnistrian, and Russian politicians and state officials issued statements in support of Guțul along with Moldovan politicians from the "Victory" electoral bloc and the Party of Socialists of the Republic of Moldova; detentions of 69 protesters-for-hire organized by Ilan Șor.

Key Objectives and Behaviours (DISARM Red Framework)

Objective 1: [T0066: Degrade Adversary](#): damage Sandu's reputation by alleging that she is persecuting her party's political opponents ahead of the parliamentary elections and suppressing Moldovan citizens' rights for assembly.

[T00004: Develop Competing Narratives](#): frame Guțul's sentence as illegal, unfair, and inhuman, while depicting arrests of paid protesters as suppression of freedom of assembly.

[T0076: Distort](#): twist the narrative around Guțul's sentence and following protests to favor pro-Russia politicians.

[T0079: Divide](#): create conflict within Moldovan society by portraying Gagauzians as supporters of Guțul and juxtaposing them to the rest of the country, especially the central Moldovan government.

[T0117: Attract Traditional Media](#): make statements about Guțul's sentence and spread appeals to support her with the goal to drive coverage in legacy media

Recommendations and Actions Taken

Actions Taken: Incident alert distributed to relevant parties and prepared to be included in the final report about foreign malign interference in Moldova parliamentary elections.

Recommendations: Strengthen counter-disinformation messaging; Coordinate messaging across Moldovan governmental branches; Avoid escalations provoked by Moldova's adversaries.

Report	Threat Actor	Evidence	Authors	Platforms	FIMI Assessment
N/A	Russia.	Upon Request	Larissa Doroshenko, Alliance for Securing Democracy Nika Aleksejeva, DFRLab	Telegram, Facebook, YouTube, TikTok, VK, Rumble, online media outlets	High Certainty